DIGITAL LITERACY

NMGC CASE STUDY

The Digital Divide Within: From Basic Tools to Responsible Digital Citizenship

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Section A: Establish the Context

In today's digital learning environment, students are constantly engaged with online tools and platforms. The case of Arjun, a second-year engineering student, reflects this reality. He actively uses platforms for creating profiles, sharing work, and collaborating with peers. However, his experience reveals a deeper issue — being digitally active does not necessarily mean being digitally aware.

Most students today are "digitally active" but not necessarily "digitally aware".The main issue highlighted in the case study is the gap between using digital tools and understanding how they function. While students are comfortable using platforms like linkedin,github and canva, they often lack awareness of concepts such as data privacy, content originality, and ethical usage.For example-A user may create professional posters using Canva like they can drag-and-drop elements and use templates,But may not understand design principles like contrast, alignment, or hierarchy. This gap is significant because it affects not only individual competence and adaptability but also the ability to engage critically and responsibly in an increasingly digital world.

The widespread availability of digital platforms such as Canva, Google Docs, and GitHub has made it very easy for students to produce polished and professional-looking work. However, this ease of use often creates an illusion of digital competence. Many students know how to navigate these tools, use templates, and follow tutorials, but they do not fully understand the underlying concepts that make these systems work.

For example, a student may design an impressive presentation using Canva or collaborate efficiently on Google Docs, yet may not understand design principles or how real-time synchronization actually functions. Similarly, someone might upload projects on GitHub without understanding version control or repository structure. In such cases, the focus shifts from learning concepts to simply achieving output.

This illusion is further strengthened by online visibility through platforms like LinkedIn, where having a well-maintained profile or showcasing projects can make someone appear highly skilled. However, visibility does not necessarily reflect true understanding or problem-solving ability. The case clearly differentiates between digital participation and digital literacy. Arjun actively participates in digital platforms, but his decisions such as misrepresenting skills or failing to verify information indicate a lack of true literacy. Therefore, the situation emphasizes that digital literacy goes beyond technical usage and requires awareness, critical thinking, and responsible decision-making.

SECTION-B Digital Identity and Ethics

Building a digital presence through platforms like LinkedIn or GitHub can definitely help students, but it's not as straightforward as it seems. On paper, these platforms promise equal opportunity—anyone, regardless of background, can showcase their work. In reality, though, this ideal is only partially true. Students with better access to guidance, resources, or mentorship often present their profiles more effectively, which creates an uneven playing field despite the "open for all" nature.

Another issue is the shift from learning to performing. Many students start focusing more on how their profiles look rather than what they actually know. A well-designed GitHub page or an active LinkedIn profile can sometimes give the impression of competence, even if the depth of understanding is limited. This creates a culture where visibility is mistaken for ability.

Misrepresentation is also quite common. Some level of exaggeration—like polishing descriptions or highlighting partial work—is often seen as normal in competitive environments. However, there's a thin line between presenting yourself well and being misleading. Crossing that line can harm credibility in the long run, especially when real skills are tested.

Lastly, digital permanence adds another layer of pressure. What students post today can stay online

for years. While holding people accountable is important, it’s also unfair to judge past actions without considering growth and awareness over time.

Overall, building a digital presence is beneficial, but only when approached honestly and thoughtfully. Otherwise, it can create more pressure and risk than actual value.

Platforms allowed Arjun to create profiles on multiple platforms, giving him the opportunity to showcase his abilities. This reflects the idea that digital platforms can democratize opportunities. However, in practice, Arjun’s profile appeared more impressive than his actual skills, indicating that visibility can sometimes overshadow authenticity. Arjun’s behavior illustrates how students often focus on presenting themselves in the best possible light rather than developing genuine competence. His incomplete code repositories and superficial contributions suggest that performance is prioritized over learning.

Another important aspect is digital permanence. Arjun’s early mistakes remain visible on his profiles, which could affect how he is perceived in the future. This highlights the long-term consequences of careless digital behavior.

Thus, while digital presence can enhance opportunities, it must be built on authenticity and responsibility to avoid long-term negative consequences

SECTION-C: Collaboration vs. Misuse

Digital collaboration platforms have become a normal part of modern learning, especially with tools like Google Docs, coding platforms such as GitHub, and shared workspaces like Notion. They clearly make group work faster and more connected, but whether they actually improve learning is a more complicated question.

On one hand, these platforms do enhance learning in meaningful ways. Students can work together in real time, exchange ideas instantly, and learn from each other's approaches. For example, in coding projects, seeing how someone else structures logic or fixes errors can teach more than just reading theory. At the same time, there is a downside—these tools can also make it easier to depend on others. Instead of struggling through a problem, some students may simply copy solutions or rely heavily on teammates, which reduces actual understanding. So, the same tool that enables learning can also enable shortcuts.

The boundary between collaboration and academic dishonesty is not always clear. Discussing ideas, dividing work, and reviewing each other's contributions are generally acceptable. But directly copying someone's work or presenting shared output as individual effort crosses into unethical territory. The problem is that digital platforms blur this line. When everything is shared and editable, it becomes difficult to define where help ends and cheating begins. In many cases, the boundary is not strictly defined but depends on context, instructions, and intent.

Another issue is the reduced visibility of individual effort.
In a shared document or repository, multiple people contribute, but it's not always obvious who did what. While tools like version history exist, they are not always checked. This lack of clear accountability can make ethical behavior harder to enforce, because it allows individuals to hide behind group work. At the same time, it can also create unfair situations where some students contribute more but receive equal credit.
The strongest argument in favor of digital collaboration is that it reflects real-world working environments. In most professional settings, people rarely work in isolation—they collaborate, share knowledge, and build on each other's ideas. These platforms prepare students for that reality. They also make learning more interactive and less rigid, encouraging discussion, peer learning, and faster problem-solving. Restricting such tools could limit exposure to these important skills.
However, I don't fully agree that they should be completely unrestricted. While they do improve learning, the risk of misuse is real and quite common. Without proper guidelines, students may prioritize completing tasks over actually understanding them. So instead of restricting the platforms, there should be clearer rules, better monitoring, and more emphasis on individual accountability within group work.
In the end, digital collaboration platforms are neither entirely beneficial nor harmful. Their impact depends on how they are used. When used responsibly, they can significantly enhance learning, but without awareness and structure, they can just as easily weaken it.

SECTION-D : CYBER AWARENESS AND RESPONSIBILITY

Cyber crime is often talked about as a technical problem, but in everyday student life it is more of a behavioral one. Even with constant warnings about phishing links, fake job offers, or OTP frauds, these attacks still work—and not just on inexperienced users.

One reason they continue to succeed is that awareness does not always translate into action. Students may *know* about phishing in theory, but in real situations decisions are made quickly and emotionally. A message that looks urgent ("your account will be blocked") or attractive ("you've been selected for an internship") triggers fear or excitement. In that moment, logic takes a backseat. Attackers understand this well; they don't rely on breaking systems, they rely on manipulating people.

Also, many scams today are highly convincing—they mimic real platforms, use correct logos, and even replicate official communication styles. So the gap is not just lack of knowledge, but how people behave under pressure.

When it comes to responsibility, it is shared, but not equally. Users are expected to follow basic precautions—strong passwords, not sharing OTPs, verifying links. However, expecting every student to consistently make perfect decisions in a fast-moving digital environment is unrealistic. Platforms and institutions design the systems people interact with, so they carry a larger responsibility to make those systems safer by default. If a phishing email can perfectly imitate a trusted service, or if a fake website can look identical to a real one, then the system

itself has weaknesses. So while users must be careful, platforms should reduce the chances of mistakes turning into serious harm.

In the case where a student falls victim to a scam due to lack of awareness, calling it simple negligence feels unfair. It is partly a lack of education, but also a systemic issue. Many students are told “don’t click unknown links,” but they are not taught how to actually identify a suspicious pattern in a realistic situation. There is a difference between theoretical awareness and practical digital judgment. If someone has never been trained to recognize subtle red flags, their mistake is not just personal—it reflects a gap in how digital safety is taught.

Current preventive measures also have limitations. Password rules, awareness campaigns, and general guidelines are necessary, but they mostly address surface-level behavior. They assume that if people are informed, they will act correctly. In reality, habits, convenience, and overconfidence play a big role. For example, students reuse passwords because it is easier, or ignore warnings because they appear too frequently. Over time, people become desensitized to alerts. This shows that the problem is not just about information, but about human behavior—how people prioritize speed, trust familiar patterns, and underestimate risk.

So the persistence of cyber crime is not surprising. It survives in the gap between what people know and how they actually act. Unless solutions go beyond giving instructions and start addressing decision-making, habits, and system design, these risks will continue to exist in everyday student life.

SECTION E COMMUNICATION AND DIGITAL ETTIQUETE

Communication in digital spaces looks simple, but it actually affects how people are seen and what opportunities they get. Many students already know basic rules like using proper greetings, clear language, or avoiding slang in formal emails. Still, they often don't follow them. One reason is habit. Most communication today happens on chats and social media, where short forms, emojis, and casual tone are normal. When students switch to email, they carry the same style without thinking much about it. Another reason is speed—people want to reply quickly, so they don't focus on tone or structure.

Informal communication is definitely becoming more common, even in professional spaces. Messages are shorter, less rigid, and more direct than before. In some ways, this is a natural change. Workplaces are becoming more flexible, and communication is expected to be quick and efficient. But it can also be a problem. When everything becomes too casual, it can reduce clarity and sometimes come across as careless or disrespectful, especially in formal situations like job applications or talking to professors.

Judging someone based on their digital communication style is tricky, but it does happen. A poorly written email or careless message can create a negative first impression, even if the person is capable. On the other hand, being too formal or “perfect” all the time can feel unnatural. So it’s not about being perfect, but about understanding the context. How you communicate online affects how seriously people take you, and that can influence opportunities like internships, projects, or collaborations.

In the end, digital communication is not just about sending messages.

SECTION F : REFLECTION

Before working on this case study, I honestly thought “digital literacy” just meant knowing how to use tools properly—like making presentations, using Google Docs, or maybe some basic coding. For me, it was more about *skills*. Now I feel it’s much deeper than that. It’s not just about using technology, but understanding how it affects decisions, behaviour, and even how we present ourselves. I didn’t really think about things like digital risk, misrepresentation, or how small actions online can have long-term effects.

One thing that surprised me was how easily we confuse activity with actual learning. I realized that just because I’m active on different platforms doesn’t mean I’m actually improving my understanding. Also, the idea of digital permanence made me a bit uncomfortable. I never really thought that something I post casually today could still matter years later. It made me reflect on how casually I sometimes treat online spaces.

If I’m being honest, I think I use digital platforms decently, but not completely responsibly. There are times when I take shortcuts, like quickly copying something just to finish a task, or not really checking the authenticity of links or information. I also don’t always pay attention to how I communicate in emails or messages, especially when I’m in a hurry.

If I had to change one thing, it would be being more mindful before acting online—whether it’s posting something, clicking a link, or even submitting work. I feel like most mistakes don’t happen because we don’t know, but because we don’t pause and think. Overall, this case study made me realize that being digitally literate is less about tools and more about awareness and responsibility.